5 | From War to Peace: Yom Kippur to Camp David 1973–8

Key question
Why did Egypt and Syria attack Israel in 1973?

At the end of the Six-Day War in 1967 there was no peace treaty. In fact, fighting broke out again in 1968 between Israel and Egypt over the Suez Canal. The Egyptians wished to clear the Canal of sunken ships but the Israelis, who now occupied Sinai, would only agree to this if Egypt allowed their ships through the Canal. Over the next two years there were many clashes across the Canal. Both Egypt and Israel lost many men and weapons and, by 1970, both sides were tiring. Nasser had not received the support he had hoped for from other Arab states nor had he managed to dislodge the Israelis. Meanwhile, Egyptian cities on the Canal were regularly pulverised by Israeli guns in this '**war of attrition**'.

Key term
War of attrition
A war in which each side tries to wear the other out.

President Sadat and the origins of the war

In September 1970 Nasser died and was succeeded by his Vice-President, Anwar Sadat. Like Nasser, Sadat had been an army officer. He realised that the fighting over the Suez Canal was draining Egypt of money and morale. The Canal could not be used and fighting could flare up at any time. Egypt had to keep nearly a million men ready to fight and this was very expensive. Peace was needed in order to clear the Canal and rebuild Egypt's cities. However, the overriding objective for Egypt was to regain Sinai, the land which it had lost in 1967. Sadat promised his people that the year 1971 'would not end without the conflict with Israel having been settled'.

Key date
Anwar Sadat became President of Egypt: 1970

'No peace, no war'

Sadat was prepared to recognise the state of Israel in order to regain the lost land. However, the Israelis were unwilling to discuss it and Sadat knew he could not defeat Israel in war. He also knew that only the USA could force Israel to enter into peace



President Sadat of Egypt. He promised to settle the conflict with Israel.